

Command Structures

SEAPOWER THROUGH ENGINEERING

TOPIC LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Upon successful completion of this topic, the student will be able to:

1. Identify the impact of the Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act on the chains of command within Department of War (DoW).
2. Recognize the major components of the DoW and DoN.
3. Identify the reporting chain of command (operational or administrative) for various DoW/DoN organizations and individuals.
4. Identify the Secretary of the Navy's principal advisors and assistants by title and responsibilities.
5. Recognize the definitions of common Navy terminology and acronyms (PAE, DRPM, OPNAV, and echelon).
6. Identify the CNO's principal advisors and assistants by title and responsibilities.
7. Identify the mission of COMUSFLTFORCOM.
8. Recognize the difference between Type Commanders and Numbered Fleet Commanders.
9. Recognize the relationship of the TYCOMS, Providers, and Resource Sponsors to the Warfare Enterprises.
10. Identify EDO Flag billets by name and responsibility.
11. Understand how legacy DoW acquisition structures are transitioning to a modernized, mission-centric framework to enable rapid capability delivery.

STUDENT PREPARATION

Student Support Material

1. None

Primary References

1. Goldwater–Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1986 Pub.L. 99–433
2. National Defense Authorization (FY26) https://www.congress.gov/119/bills/s2296/BILLS-119s2296es.pdf
3. 2026 National Defense Strategy https://media.defense.gov/2026/Jan/23/2003864773/-1/-1/0/2026-NATIONAL-DEFENSE-STRATEGY.PDF

Additional References

1. SECNAVINST 5400.15D: DoN Research and Development, Acquisition, Associated Life-Cycle Management, and Sustainment Responsibilities and Accountability
2. OPNAVINST 5450.352A:CNO Mission, Functions, Tasks
3. Web Pages:
   A. Department of War: https://www. war.gov
   B. Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS): https://www.jcs.mil/
   C. https://www.war.gov/Experience/Military-Units/Navy/#1309
   D. https://www.secnav.navy.mil/rda/Pages/ASNRDAOrgChart.aspx

Overview

- History of Goldwater-Nichols
- Major DoW/DoN components and reporting chains
  - Admin and Operational
- Deeper dive into DoN
  - SECNAV, CNO, ASN(RD&A), USFFC
- What is an “Enterprise”
- Key people
  - Engineering Duty Admirals

U.S. Government

- Constitution establishes three branches of Government
  - Article 1: Legislative Branch (Congress)
    - Section 8: Powers of Congress
      - To provide and maintain a Navy
      - Declare war
  - Article 2: Executive Branch (President)
    - Section 2: Civilian control over the military
  - Article 3: Judicial (Courts)

Before Goldwater-Nichols

- World War II and even earlier
  - Secretary of the Navy, Secretary of War, Service Chiefs, Fleet Commanders and Army Commanders
    - Dual roles: Force Provider and Force Commander
- National Security Act of 1947. Established National Military Establishment
  - Established the SECDEF, Central Intelligence Agency, National Security Council, US Air Force
  - War Department became Department of the Air Force and Department of the Army
  - Made the Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) a 'formal' body with the Chairman (as an official title)
- National Military Establishment renamed Department of Defense in 1949

Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act of 1986

- Changes
  - Primary: Improve the ability of the Armed Services to conduct Joint operations
  - Secondary: Improve DoD Budget and Acquisition processes
- Why
  - Inter-Service rivalries
    - In combat (Vietnam, Iranian hostage rescue, Grenada)
    - In acquisition
    - In the development of war fighting doctrine
  - Officers did not know very much about the other services

Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act of 1986 (cont.)

- Defines core command structure and joint operations for the DoW
- Three big pieces of the Act
  - Increased the responsibilities of the Chairman JCS
    - Principal military advisor to the President, SECDEF, National Security Council
  - Increase the authority of the Combatant Commands
    - OPCON: President to SECWAR to Combatant Commands
    - ADCON: Service Department Secretaries 'Man, Train, Equip' forces for Combatant Commanders
  - Instituted and established ***Jointness***
    - In the budget process, Officer Training (JPME), Alignment of Program Executive Offices (PEOs) to Service Acquisition Executive
    - Portfolio Acquisition Executives (PAEs) have replaced the PEOs

Requirements and Acquisition Reform 2025-2026

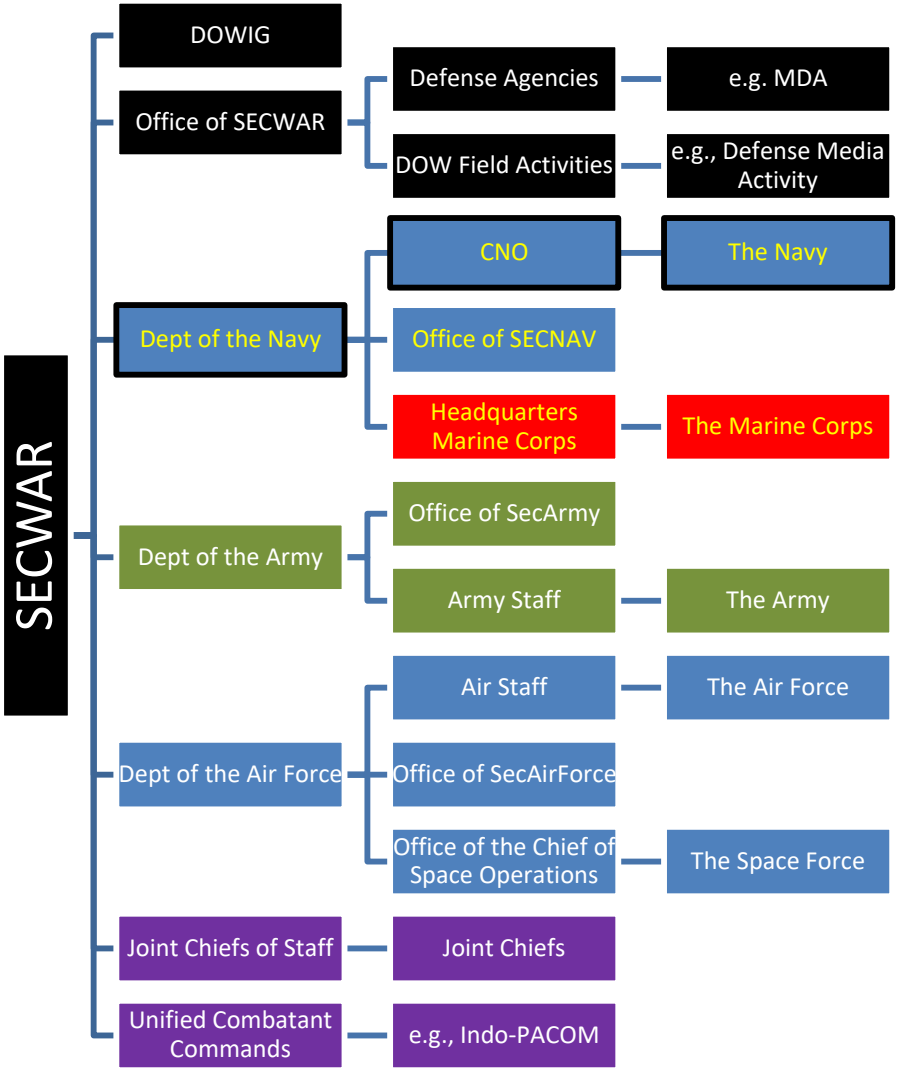
- Established the Joint Force Requirements Process (JFRP)
  - Replaced the Joint Capability Integration and Development System (JCIDS)
- Established the Portfolio Acquisition Executives (PAEs)
  - Replaced Program Executive Offices (PEOs)
  - Shift away from management of isolated programs to a broader, mission centric approach
- Defense Acquisition System rebranded as the Warfighting Acquisition System
  - Defense Acquisition University (DAU) rebranded as Warfighting Acquisition University (WarU)
- Why
  - To change our mindset and approach to acquisition writ large
  - Outpace peer competitors
  - To empower single leaders to make trades between cost, schedule, and performance
  - Speed

The JFRP fixed how the military defines what it needs; the PAE restructure overhauls how we buy those capabilities

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- Key people
  - Engineering Duty Admirals

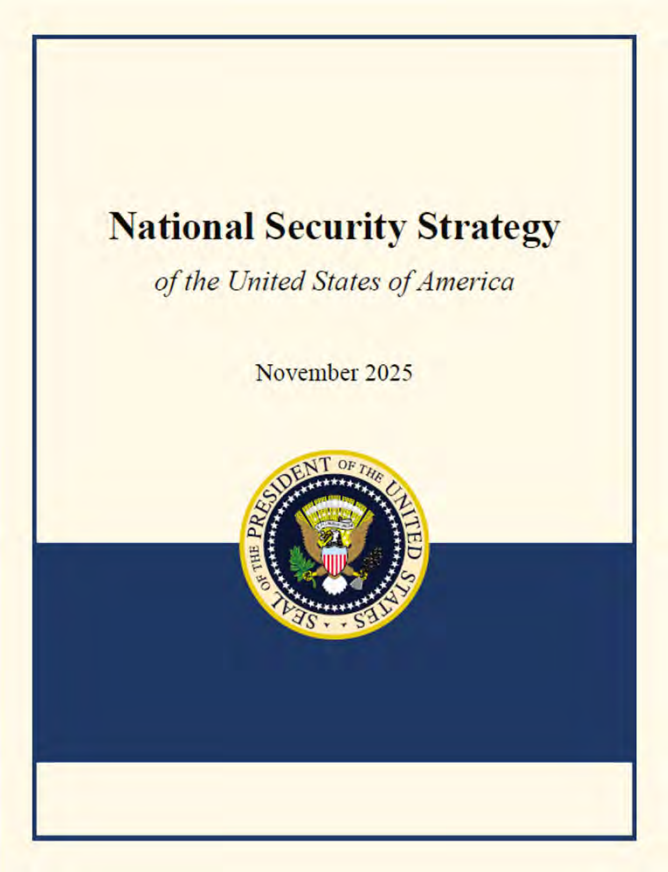
DoW and DoN


SECWAR
DOWIG
Office of SECWAR
Defense Agencies
e.g. MDA
DOW Field Activities
e.g., Defense Media Activity
Dept of the Navy
CNO
The Navy
Office of SECNAV
Headquarters Marine Corps
The Marine Corps
Dept of the Army
Office of SecArmy
Army Staff
The Army
Dept of the Air Force
Air Staff
The Air Force
Office of SecAirForce
Office of the Chief of Space Operations
The Space Force
Joint Chiefs of Staff
Joint Chiefs
Unified Combatant Commands
e.g., Indo-PACOM

Major Components: DoW and DoN

- Department of War (SECWAR)
  - SECWAR/DEPSECWAR/OSW Staff
  - Joint Staff
  - Service Departments (Service Secretaries)
    - Army
    - Navy/Marine Corps
    - Air Force/Space Force
  - Unified Combatant Commands
- Department of the Navy
  - SECNAV/Principal Advisors (the Secretariat)/Staff
  - CNO and OPNAV Staff
  - Shore Establishment (e.g., Systems Commands (SYSCOMs))
  - Operating Forces

2025 National Security Strategy



America First Foreign Policy: Prioritizes homeland security, replacing global commitments with a transactional, interest-based approach

Economic Nationalism: Protects U.S. industry with tariffs while seeking energy dominance through fossil fuel deregulation and ending renewable subsidies

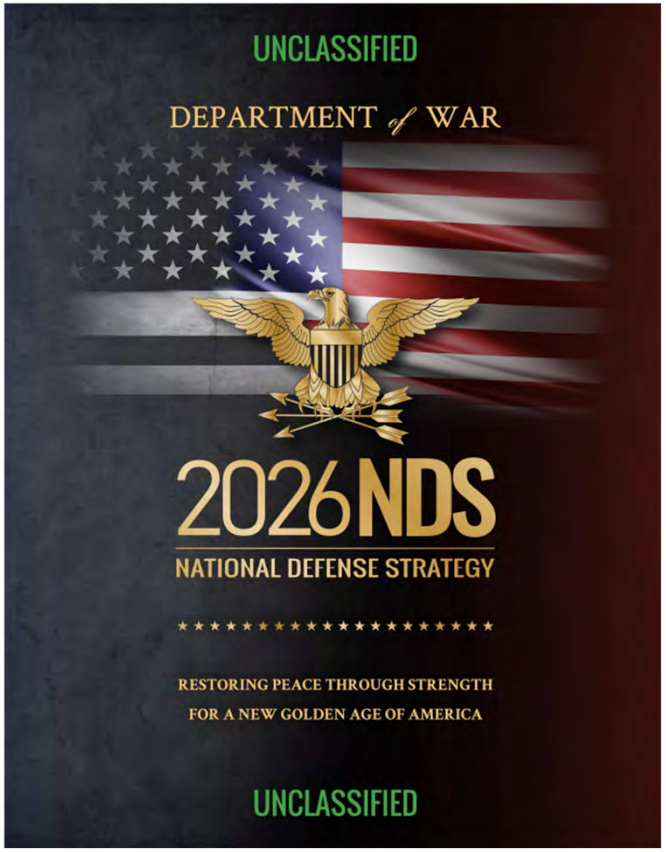
Confronting Adversaries: Identifies China as the primary long-term threat and confronts the growing alignment of China, Russia, Iran, and North Korea

Reassessing Alliances: Demands allies increase defense spending and align with U.S. interests, putting traditional commitments like NATO under review

Military Modernization: Focuses military resources on deterring and preparing for a great power conflict, specifically with China

NSS
https://www.whitehouse.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/12/2025-National-Security-Strategy.pdf

2026 National Defense Strategy



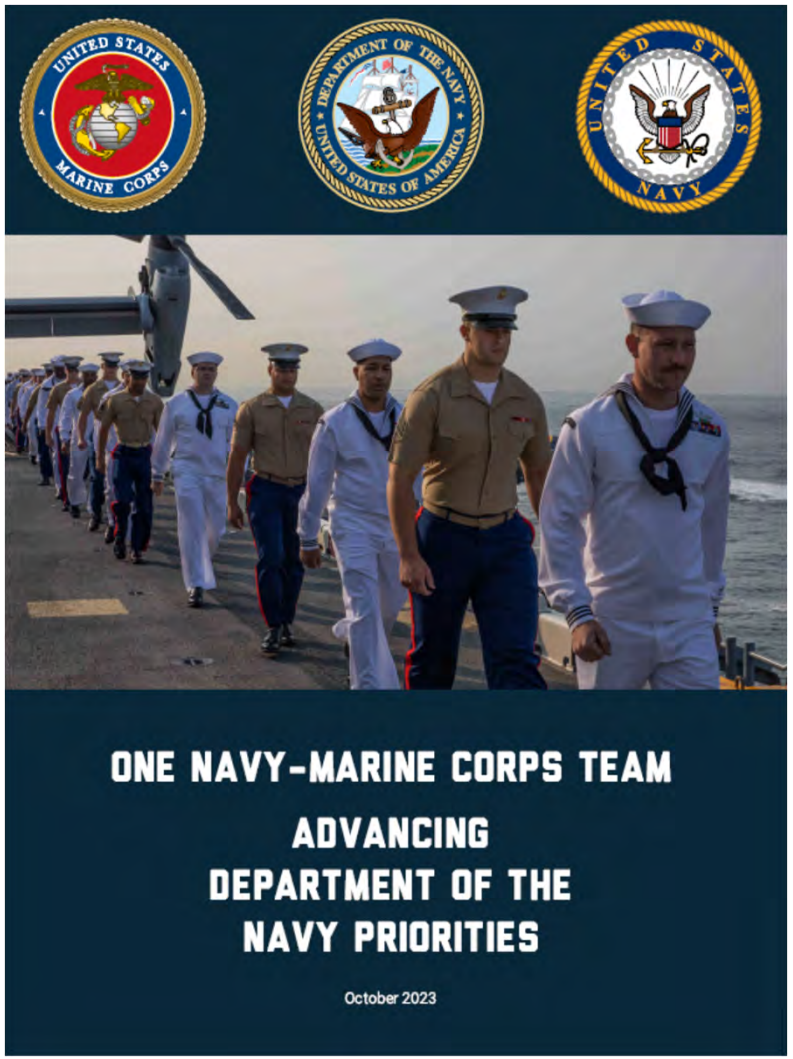
- **Strategic Approach: key lines of effort**
  1. Defend the U.S. Homeland
  2. Deter China in the Indo-Pacific Through Strength, Not Confrontation
  3. Increase Burden-Sharing with U.S. Allies and Partners
  4. Supercharge the U.S. Defense Industrial Base
- **3 ways to advance the priorities**
  1. Integrated deterrence
  2. Campaigning
  3. Building of an enduring advantage

2026 NDS

https://media.defense.gov/2026/Jan/23/2003864773/-1/-1/0/2026-NATIONAL-DEFENSE-STRATEGY.PDF

America First. Peace Through Strength. Common Sense.

SECNAV: One Navy-Marine Corps Team



Mission: DoN will recruit, train, and organize to deliver combat ready naval forces to deter and, if necessary, win conflicts and wars through sustained forward naval presence in support of the joint force

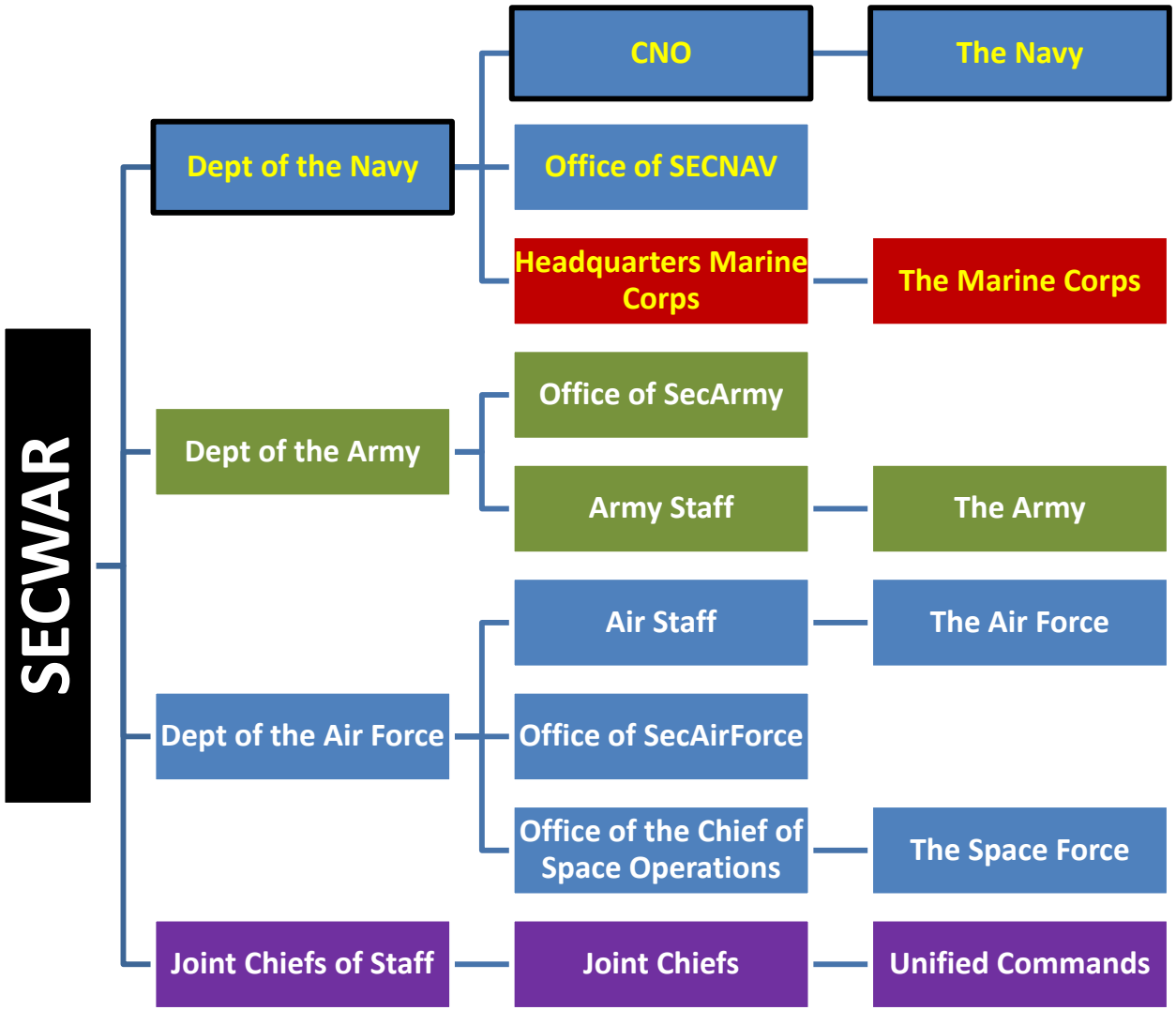
Strengthening Maritime Dominance	• Industrial Base • Climate • Uncrewed Technology • Rearm, Refuel, Repair, Revive, Resupply
Building a Culture of Warfighting Excellence	• Taking Care of People • Education • Research, Development, Science, and Technology
Enhancing Strategic Partnerships	• Naval Diplomacy • Defense Ecosystem • Congress • National Call to Service

Chains of Command

- Administrative - ADCON
  - Provides authority over subordinate commands with respect to administration and support ***"man, train, and equip"***
- Operational - OPCON
  - Provides authority over subordinate commands with respect to operations ***"combat forces - fighting wars"***
  - DoW Example: SECWAR passes operational orders to Central Command

An explanation of the Operational & Administrative Chains of Command
https://www.war.gov/Experience/Military-Units/Navy/#1309

Administrative Chain of Command



Operational Chain of Command

SECWAR

Unified Combatant Commands

Geographic COCOMS

- Africa Command
- Central Command
- European Command
- Indo-Pacific Command
- Northern Command
- Southern Command

Functional COCOMS

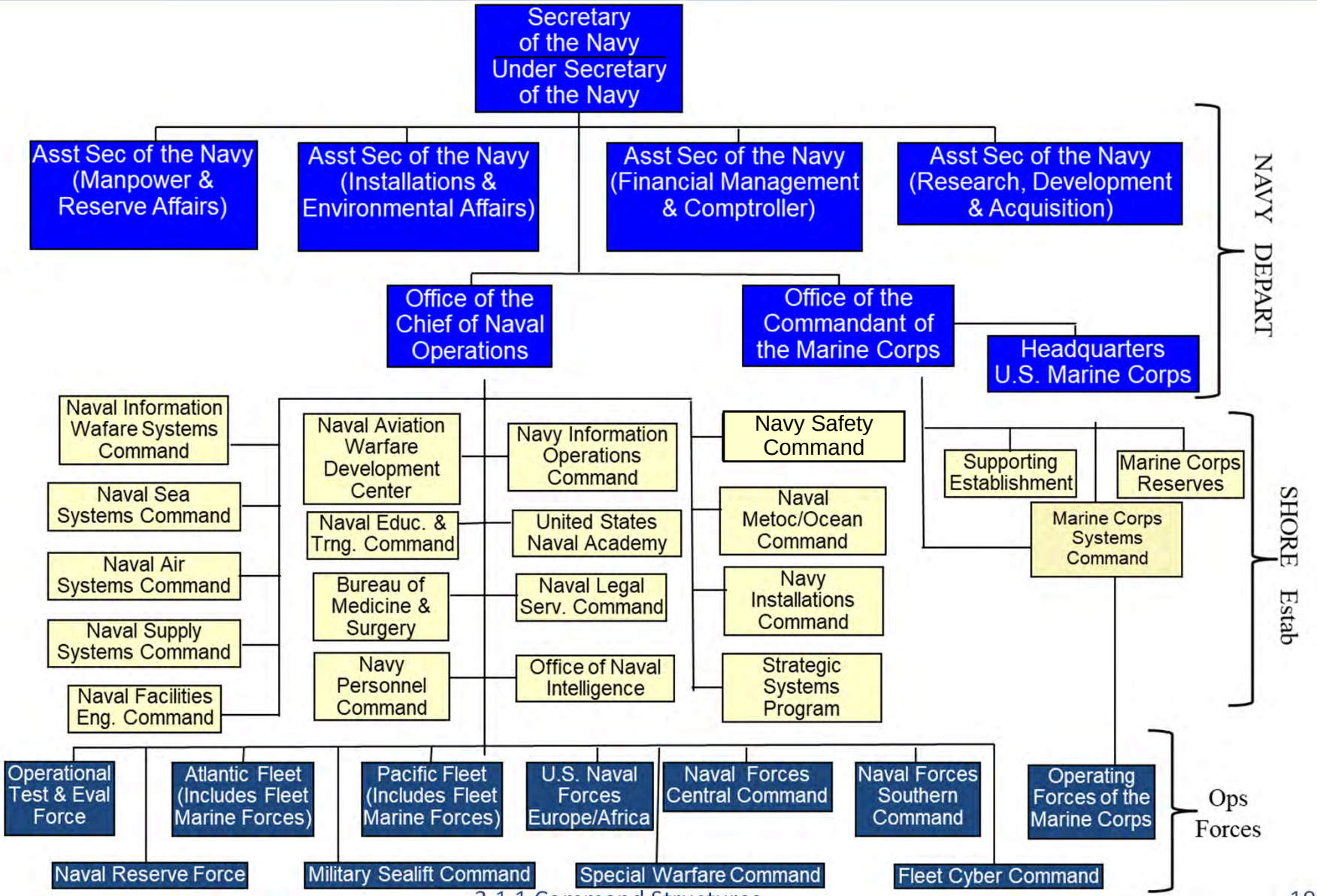
- Cyber Command
- Special Ops Command
- Strategic Command
- Transportation Command
- Space Command



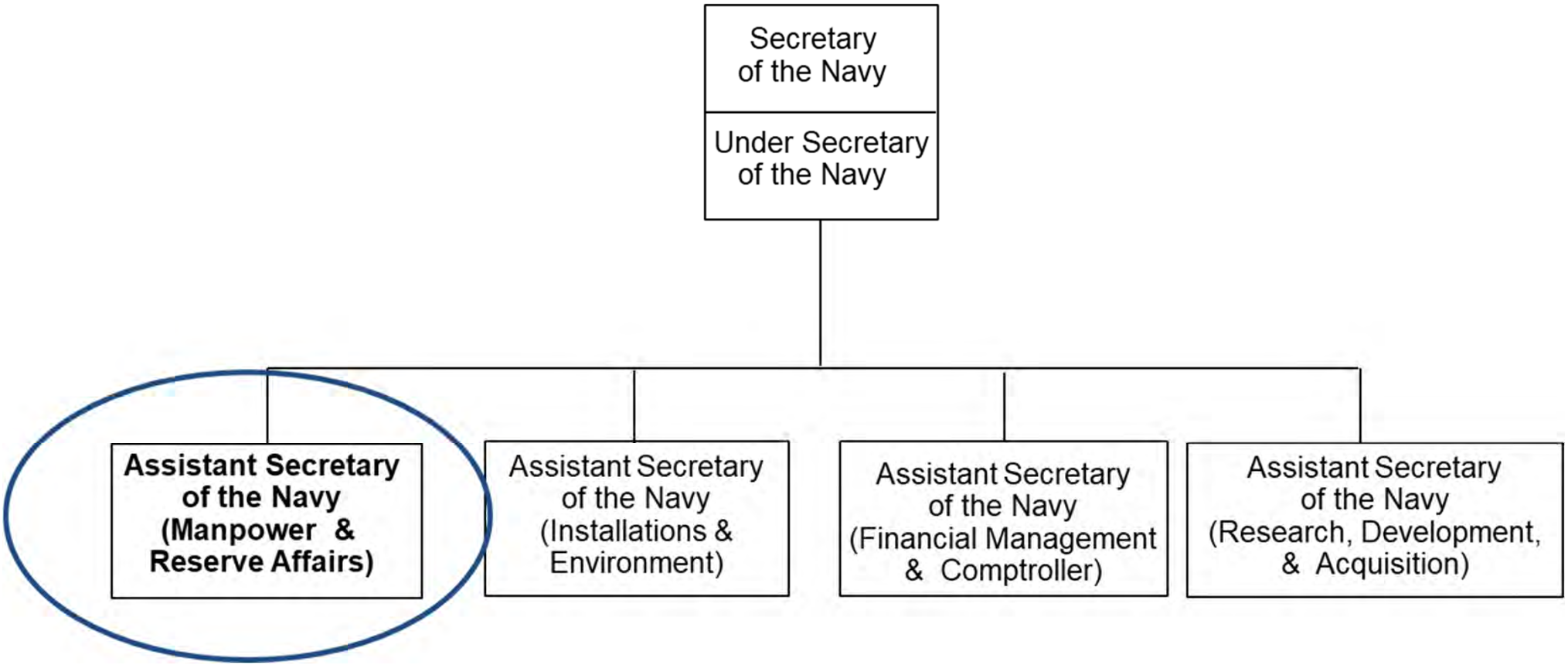
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Department of the Navy

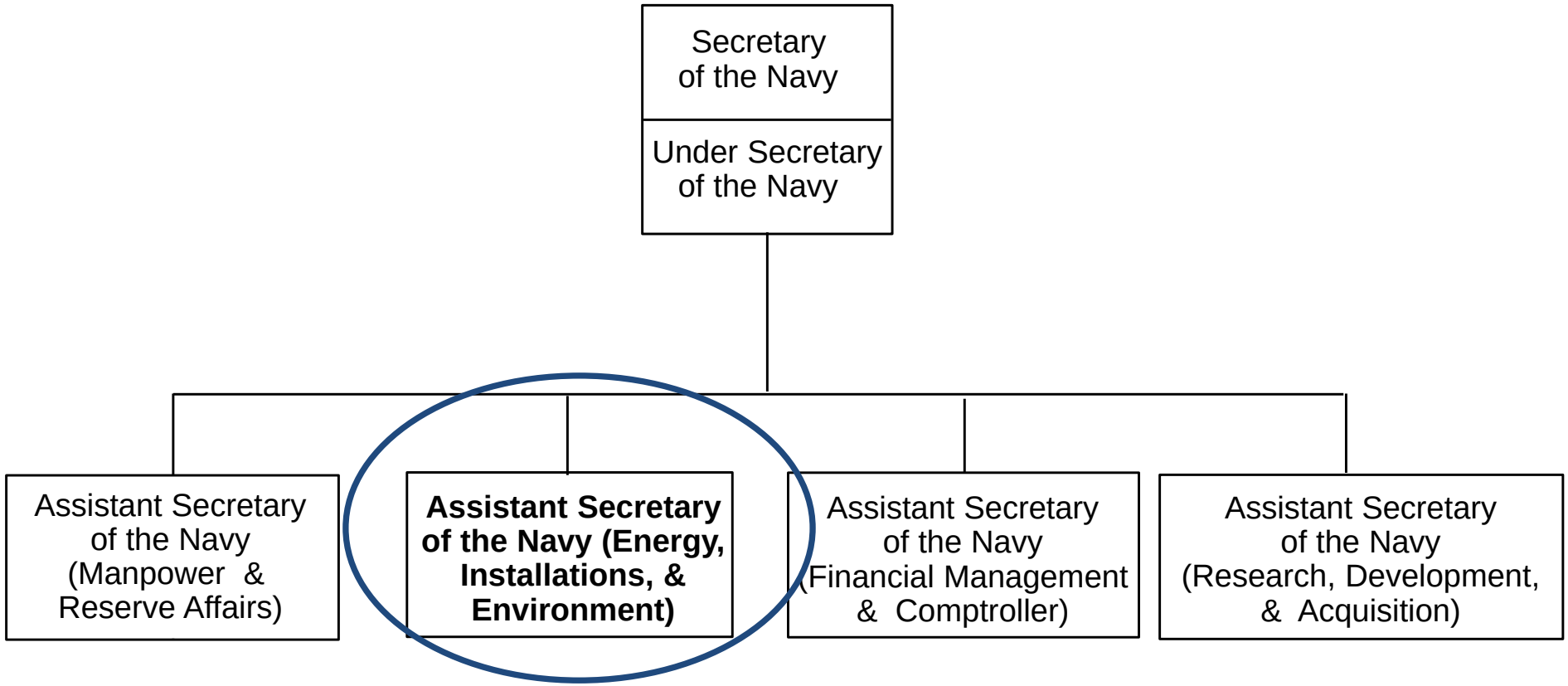


SECNAV Principal Advisors



Responsible for manpower and personnel policies, personnel readiness, quality of life and healthcare programs, and issues affecting Active Duty, Reserves, and DoN civilians

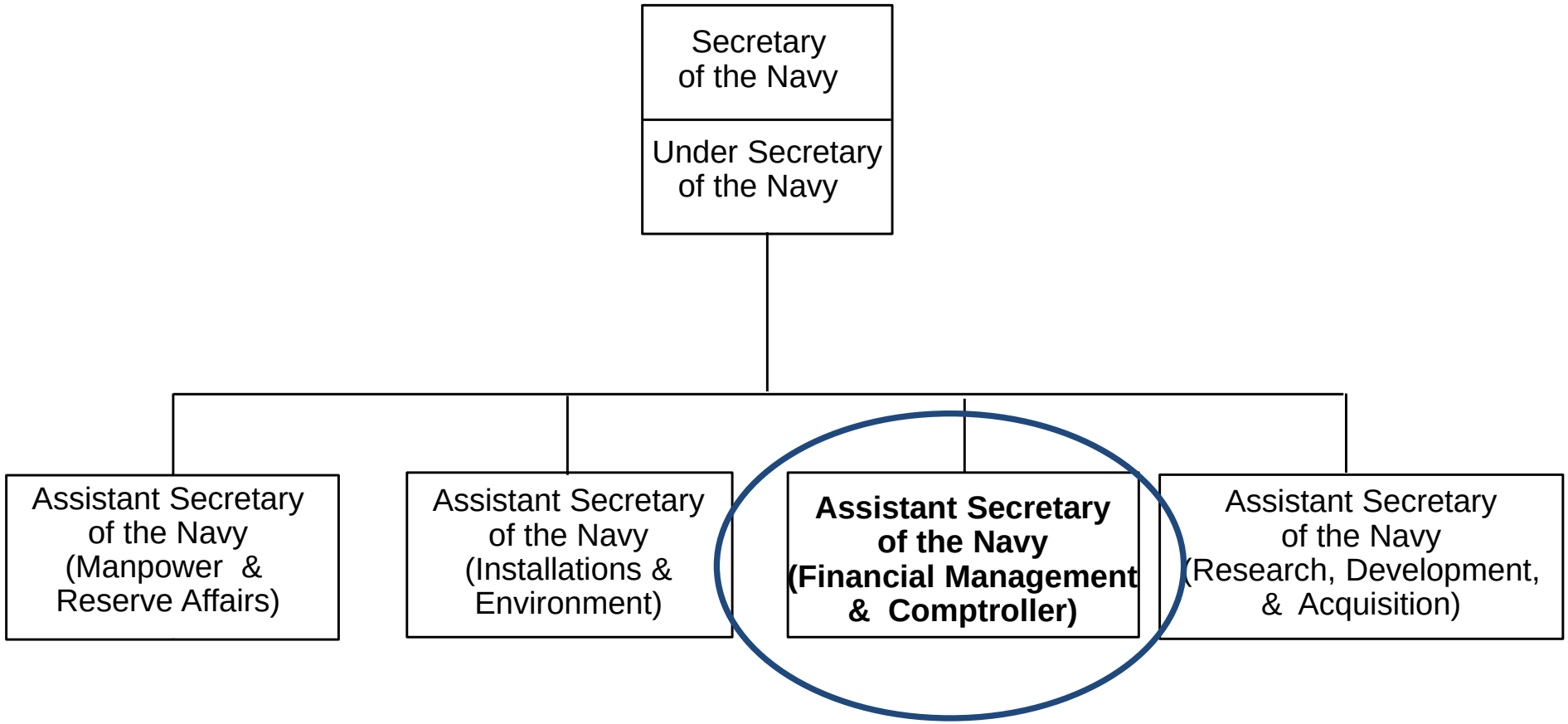
SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)



Formulates Department-wide policies and procedures for Navy and Marine Corps energy; infrastructure sustainment, restoration and modernization; military construction; acquisition, utilization and disposal of real property and facilities; environmental protection, planning, restoration and natural resources conservation; and safety and occupational health

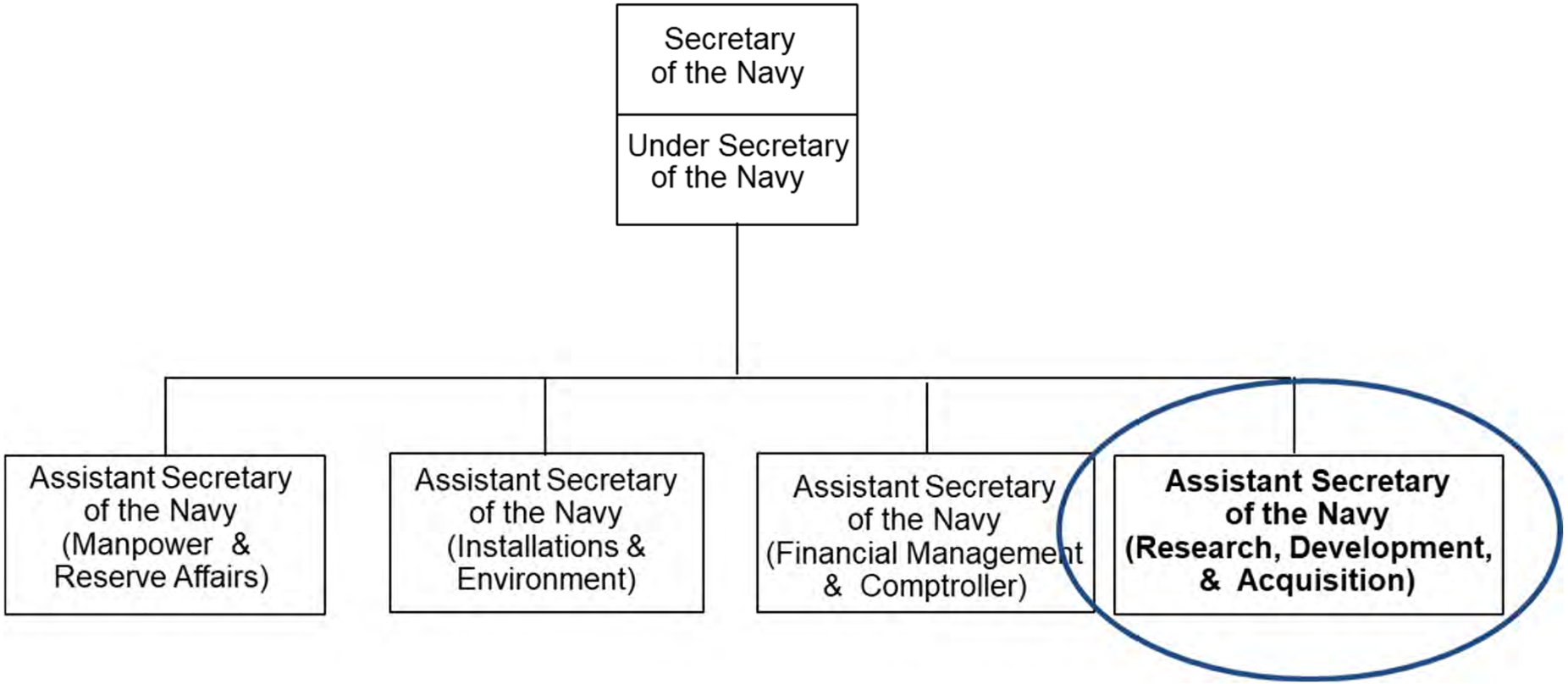
BRAC – Base Realignment and Closure

SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)



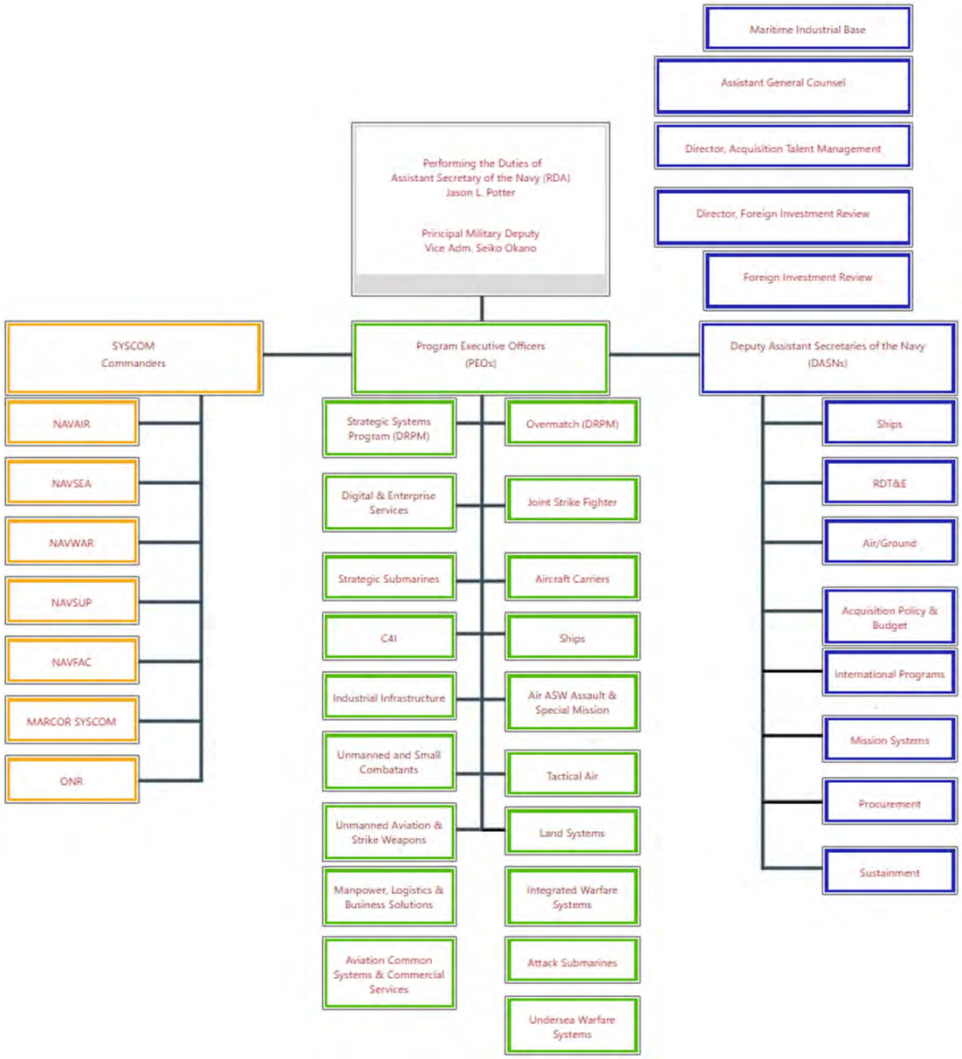
Financial Management: SECNAV's principal financial advisor
Comptroller: Execution of Navy's budget

SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)

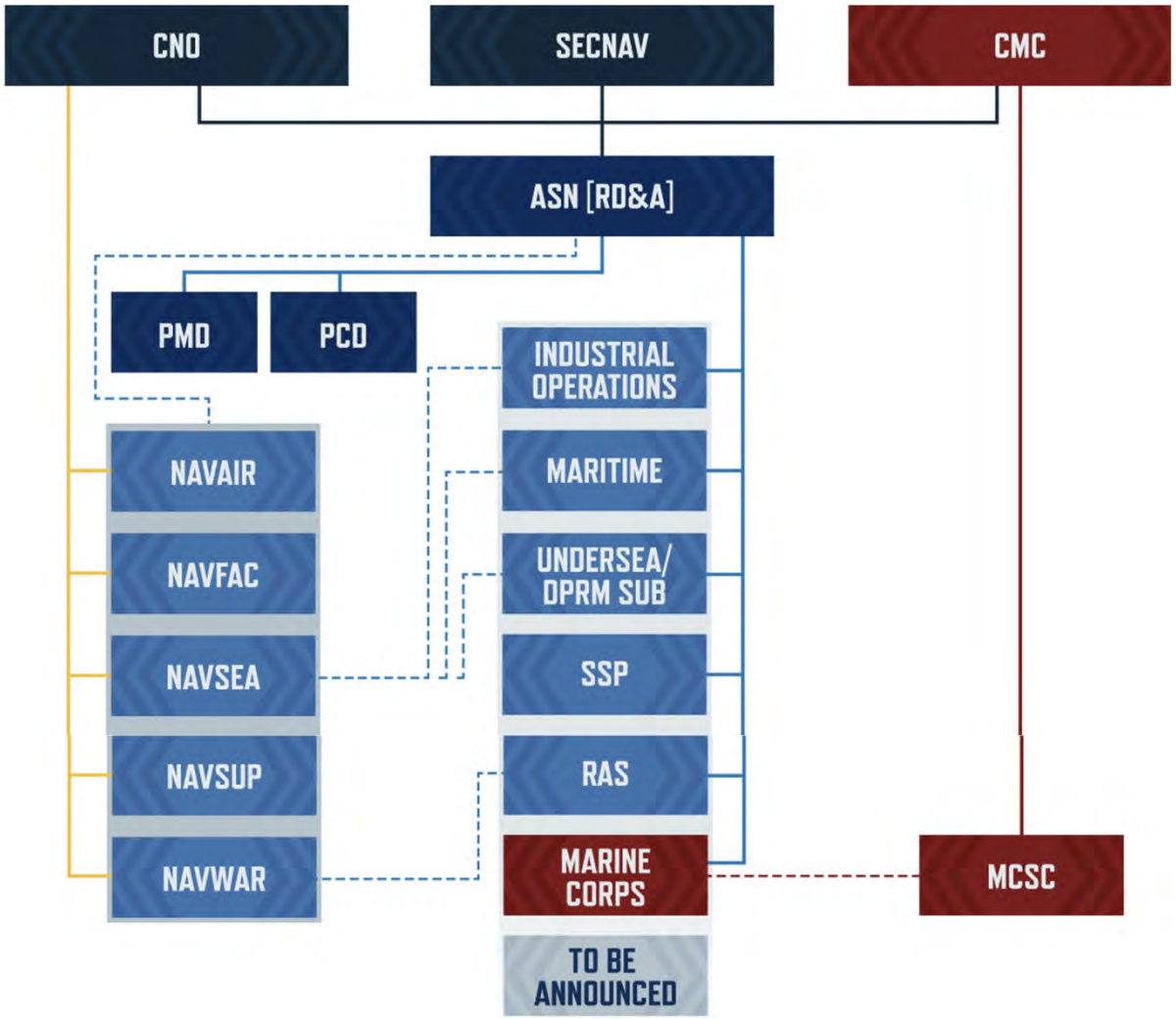


The ASN (RD&A) is the Navy's Component Acquisition Executive (CAE). Responsible for all acquisition policy and procedures

Navy Acquisition Organization



Navy Acquisition Organization
Portfolio Acquisition Executive Reform



- PAEs not listed
  - PAE Aviation
  - PAE Mission Systems
  - PAE Munitions
- DRPM (additional responsibilities)
  - DRPM SSP reports to:
    - ASN RDA for Acquisition
    - CNO for Fleet Operations, e.g., SWFs and Nuke Weapons Council
    - SECNAV for Polaris
  - DRPM SUBS - reports to DEPSECWAR
  - DRPM RAS – reports to Under Secretary of the Navy
- SYSCOM Study ongoing
  - Includes Warfare Centers

DRPM= Direct Reporting Program Manager
MCSC= Marine Corps Systems Command
PCD= Principal Civilian Deputy
PMD= Principal Military Deputy
RAS= Robotic and Autonomous Systems
SSP= Strategic Systems Programs
SWF= Strategic Weapons Facility

Assistant Secretary of the Navy, Research, Development and Acquisition (ASN(RD&A)) Guidance

- **Focus Areas**
  - Open Systems/DevSecOps/Cyber resilient systems/AI/ML
  - Focused on improving how we are advancing the art of acquisition
  - Business model is PEO/PM primary job.
    - How we are leveraging Industry, Labs, UARCs
    - Work smarter not harder
- **Key Stakeholders**
  - DoN workforce
  - American public
  - Industrial partners and academia
  - Congress
  - International partners
  - DoW and interagency partners

ASN (RDA)

- Provide improved readiness and cutting-edge capabilities to the warfighter to ensure the balance of power in strategic competition remains in our favor
- Advance nuclear modernization to sustain a strategic deterrent that is safe, secure, and effective



Mr. William F. Mahan
Performing The Duties of ASN(RDA)

- Develop the next generation of scientists and engineers to advance an international order that is conducive to collective security and prosperity
- Remain a force multiplier for US security around the world by providing allies and partners with Foreign Military Sales and international security cooperation

ASN (RDA) Structure https://www.secnav.navy.mil/rda/pages/asnrdaorgchart.aspx

Navy Acquisition Organization (cont.)

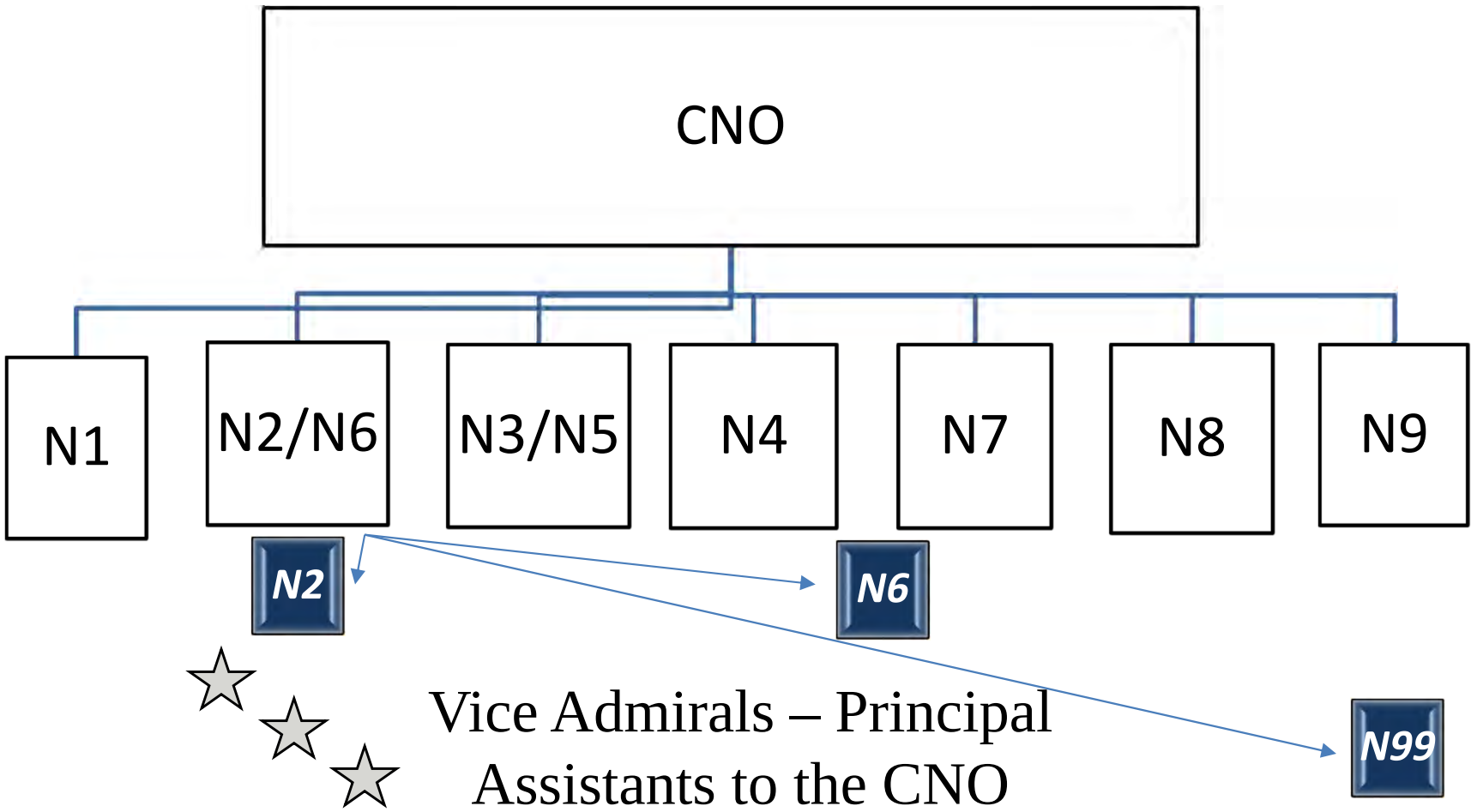
- The Assistant Secretary of the Navy for Research, Development and Acquisition (ASN(RD&A))
  - serves as the Navy Acquisition Executive
  - has authority, responsibility and accountability for all acquisition functions and programs, and for enforcement of Under Secretary of Defense for Acquisition and Sustainment (USD(A&S)) procedures
  - represents the DoN to USD(A&S) and to Congress on all matters relating to acquisition policy and programs
  - establishes policies and procedures and manages the Navy's Research, Development and Acquisition activities in accordance with DoD 5000 Series Directives
  - serves as Milestone Decision Authority on Acquisition Category (ACAT) IC programs and recommends decisions on ACAT ID programs

Navy Acquisition Organization (cont.)

- The ASN(RD&A) organization is responsible for the development and acquisition of Navy and Marine Corps platforms and weapon systems
- The organization consists of:
  - Staff to the Assistant Secretary
  - Portfolio Acquisition Executives (PAEs)
    - e.g., PAE Maritime
  - Direct Reporting Program Managers (DRPMs)
    - e.g., Strategic Systems Program (SSP), Submarines (SUBS), and Robotic and Autonomous Systems (RAS)
  - Naval Systems Commands and their field activities
- The PAEs and DRPMs are responsible for the development and acquisition of Naval systems (i.e., families of like systems (e.g., SSN))
- The Naval Systems Commands (SYSCOMS) and their field activities are also responsible for systems acquisition and supporting those systems in the operating Fleet

OPNAV Organization

Subject to Change IAW NAVADMIN 123/26



OPNAV refers to CNO and staff - OPNAV is in the administrative chain of command

Subject to Change

CNO Principal Assistants

- N1: DCNO Manpower, Personnel, Training & Education (Chief of Naval Personnel
- N2/N6: DCNO Information Warfare / Director of Naval Intelligence
- N3/N5: DCNO Plans, Policy, and Operations
- N4: DCNO Installations & Logistics
- N7: DCNO Warfighting Development
- N8: DCNO Integration of Capabilities & Resources
- N9: DCNO Warfare Systems

N2:Director of OPNAV Intelligence Division

N6N9C: Assistant DCNO for IW Requirements and Capabilities

N1 – DCNO Manpower, Personnel, Training & Education

- Responsible for overall manpower readiness. Formulates all personnel strategy and resource policies
  - N130 – Military Pay and Compensation and Policy
  - N133 – Nuclear Propulsion Program Management
  - N17 – Navy Culture and Force Resilience Office

N2/N6 – DCNO Information Warfare

- Resource sponsor for National Intelligence programs, cyber warfare, command & control, electronic warfare, oceanography, meteorology
  - N2/N6B - Assistant DCNO
  - N2/N6C - Corporate Director, IWC
  - N2/N6D - Director, Digital Warfare Office
  - N2/N6E - Director, Oceanography & Navigation
  - N2/N6I - Deputy Director, Naval Intelligence
  - N2/N6F - Director, Warfare Integration
  - N2/N6G - Director, Cybersecurity and CIO

- Changes per NAVADMIN 123/26; Establishes Director of OPNAV Intelligence Division (N2) and the following:
  - N21 - Fleet Requirements
  - N22 - Threat Analysis
  - N23 - Global Intelligence Operations and Engagements
  - N2T - Strategic Integration, and;
  - N6N9C – Assistant DCNO (ADCNO) for IW Requirements and Capabilities

N3/N5 – DCNO Ops, Plans, and Strategy

- Principal advisor on joint operations and the development of Joint strategies, plans, programs, and policies
  - N31 – Ops & Plans
  - N50 – Strategy
  - N51 – Policy
  - N52 – International Engagement
  - N53 – Asia-Pacific Advisory Group

N4 – DCNO Readiness and Logistics

- Logistic support requirements & resourcing for ordnance, supply, energy, distribution, Military Sealift Command (MSC), combat logistics, tug, rescue & salvage
  - N40 – Programming & Resources
  - N41 – Logistics Programs
  - N42 – Strategic Mobility and Combat Logistics
  - N45 – Energy & Environmental Readiness
  - N46 – Shore Readiness

N7 – DCNO Warfighting Development

- Enable the CNO to develop and ensure the Navy's warfighting advantage in order to deter, dissuade and deny, or defeat adversaries
  - N71 – Warfighting Development
    - Naval education enterprise
  - N72 – Warfare Development
    - Navy strategy and concepts
  - N73 – Strategic Warfighting Integration Cell
    - Focus on solutions for hi-pri operational problems
  - N74 – Warfighting Integration
    - Planning, concepts and campaign design & implementation

Subject to Change

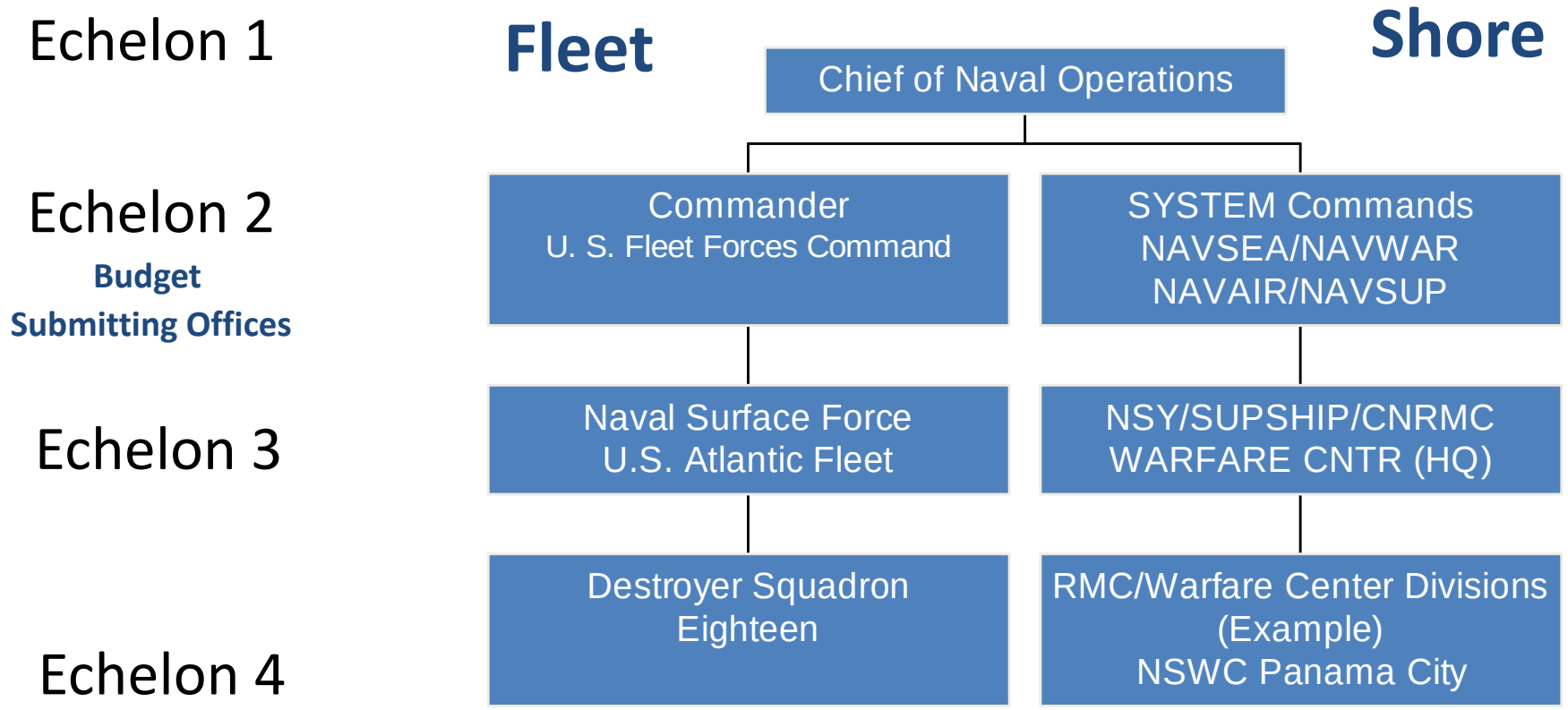
N8 – DCNO Integration of Resources and Capabilities

- Coordinates Navy capability study analyses & assessments. Allocates and integrates resources and requirements in the PPBE process
  - N80 – Director of Programming
    - Directs programming phase of Navy Planning, Programming, Budgeting and Execution Process (PPBE)
  - N81 – Director, Assessments
    - Lead for assessing warfighting capability, capacity, and wholeness
  - N82 – Director, Fiscal Management
    - Delegated responsibility for budget preparation and execution
  - N83 – Director, Fleet Readiness
    - Develop/provide maintenance requirements to platform resource sponsors

N9 – DCNO Warfare Systems

- Determines, validates, and integrates requirements and resources for manpower, training, sustainment, safety, modernization and procurement
  - N9B – Assistant DCNO
  - N9I – Director, Warfare Integration
  - N94/ONR – Director, Innovation, Tech Requirements/T&E
  - N95 – Director, Expeditionary Warfare
  - N96 – Director, Surface Warfare
  - N97 – Director, Undersea Warfare
  - N98 – Director, Air Warfare
  - N9SP – Director, Special Programs
  - N99 – Director for Information Warfare

Sample Navy Organization Chart



The Navy is organized by ***echelons*** (tiers). CNO is Echelon One. Commands reporting directly to the CNO are Echelon Two. Commands reporting directly to Echelon Two commands are Echelon Three commands, etc.

U.S. Fleet Forces Command

- Functions to support the Commander's administrative control and Title 10, U.S. Code roles, responsibilities, and missions. Two functional areas include Prepare the Force and Provide the Force

- Prepare the Force
  - Man, train, equip, organize, and maintain the readiness of U.S. Navy forces
    - Navy Readiness. Generate USN forces ready to execute service missions in support of Chief of Naval Operations (CNO) and operational missions assigned by Combatant Commanders (CCDRs) in response to force requirements
      - Includes execution of Optimized Fleet Response Plan (OFRP)
    - Navy Warfighting Capability Requirements. Articulate integrated, authoritative fleet warfighting, readiness and personnel capability requirements, coordinated with other USN Component Commanders (NCCs), to CNO and develop transformational concepts for maritime operations

U.S. Fleet Forces Command (cont.)

- Provide the Force
  - COMUSFLTFORCOM must provide ready forces to deploy and operate forward, in response to operational requirements
    - Serve as USN global force manager. Navy Global Force Management (GFM)
    - Executive Agent (EA) for Antiterrorism (AT) and Force Protection (FP)
    - Serve as primary commander in the event of a nuclear reactor or radiological accident associated with the naval nuclear propulsion program within the AORs
    - Serve as EA for damage control modernization and improvement
    - Maintenance and Modernization Resourcing
      - In conjunction with COMPACFLT, and with support from NAVSEASYSCOM, serve as the lead for collection of resource requirements, act as lead for collection and consolidation of requirements and act as the single fleet voice and point of submission of resource requirements to CNO

Type Commanders (TYCOMs)

- Work for U.S. Fleet Forces Command
- Supervise specific categories of forces and activities
  - Balance requirements and resources to meet mission capabilities
    - Manning
    - Training
    - Equipment
- Provide ready forces to the operational commander for tasking at the lowest possible cost
- Normally control a ship during its unit-level training cycle
  - After the ship completes training work ups, a ship “in chops” to the operational chain of command for deployment
  - For example, a ship is ADCON to SURFOR, OPCON to 7th Fleet
- TYCOMs are in the administrative chain of command

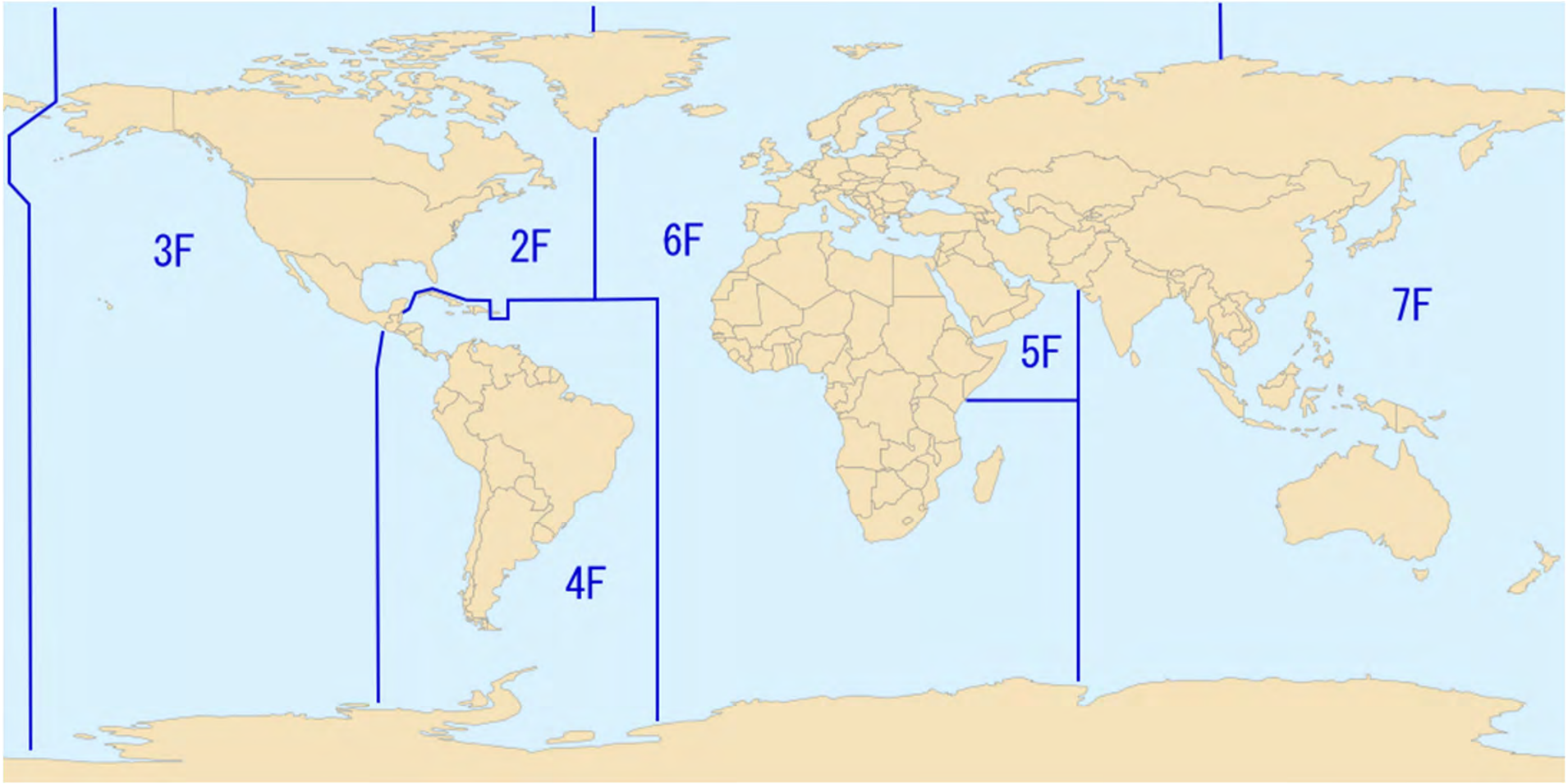
Type Commanders (TYCOMs) (cont.)

- Naval Air Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Naval Surface Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Navy Submarine Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Navy Expeditionary Combat Command
- Navy Information Warfare Forces
- Military Sealift Command
- Naval Meteorology and Oceanography Command
- Naval Special Warfare Command

Numbered Fleet Commanders

- Provide naval forces and report to the appropriate Unified Combatant Commanders
- As Navy units enter the area of responsibility, they are operationally assigned to the appropriate numbered fleet
  - 2nd, 3rd, and 4th Fleet are home-ported in U.S
    - Dual roles of force training and operations
  - 5th, 6th, and 7th Fleet are home-ported at forward locations, with forces operating in areas of responsibility
  - 10th Fleet operates in cyberspace

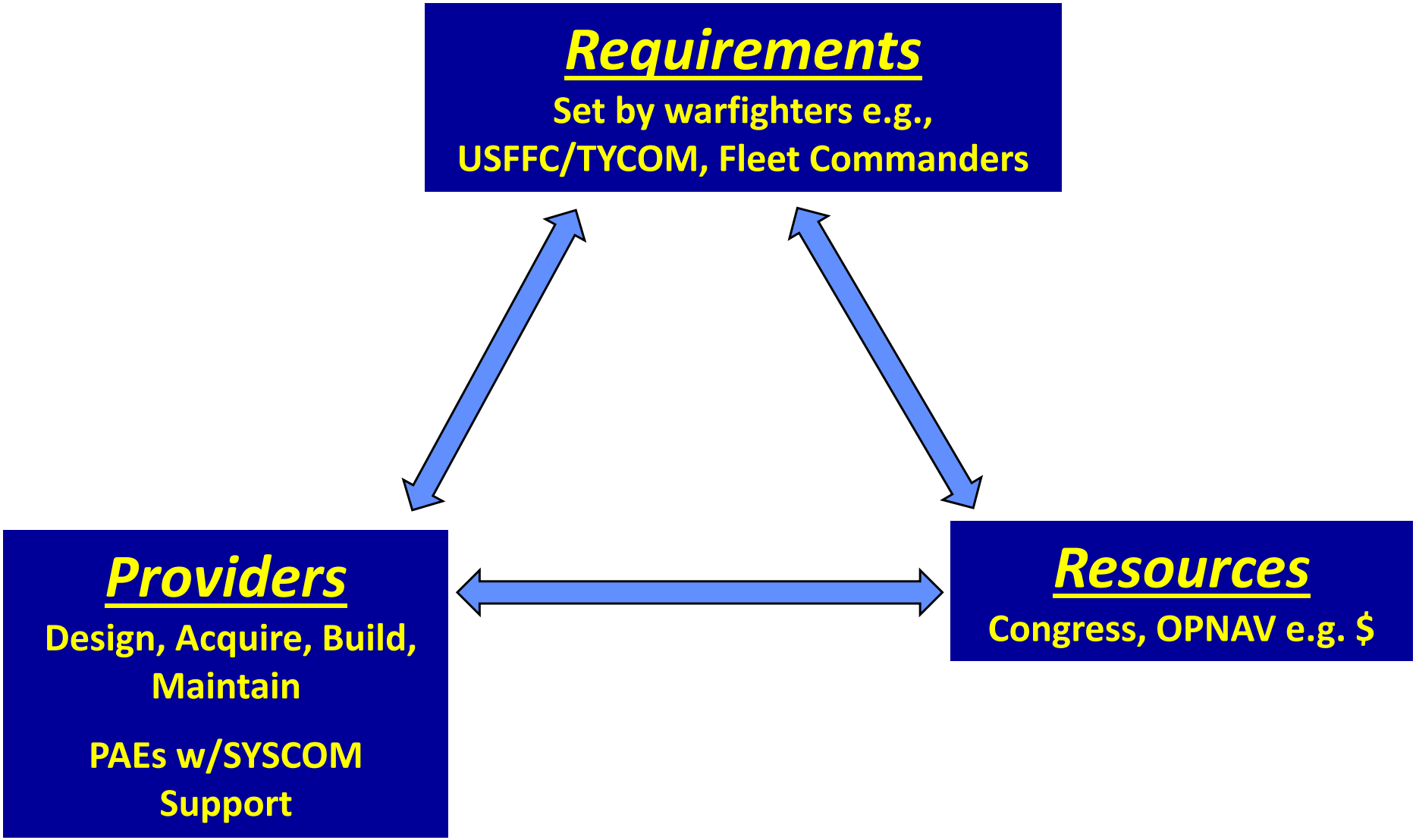
Numbered Fleets



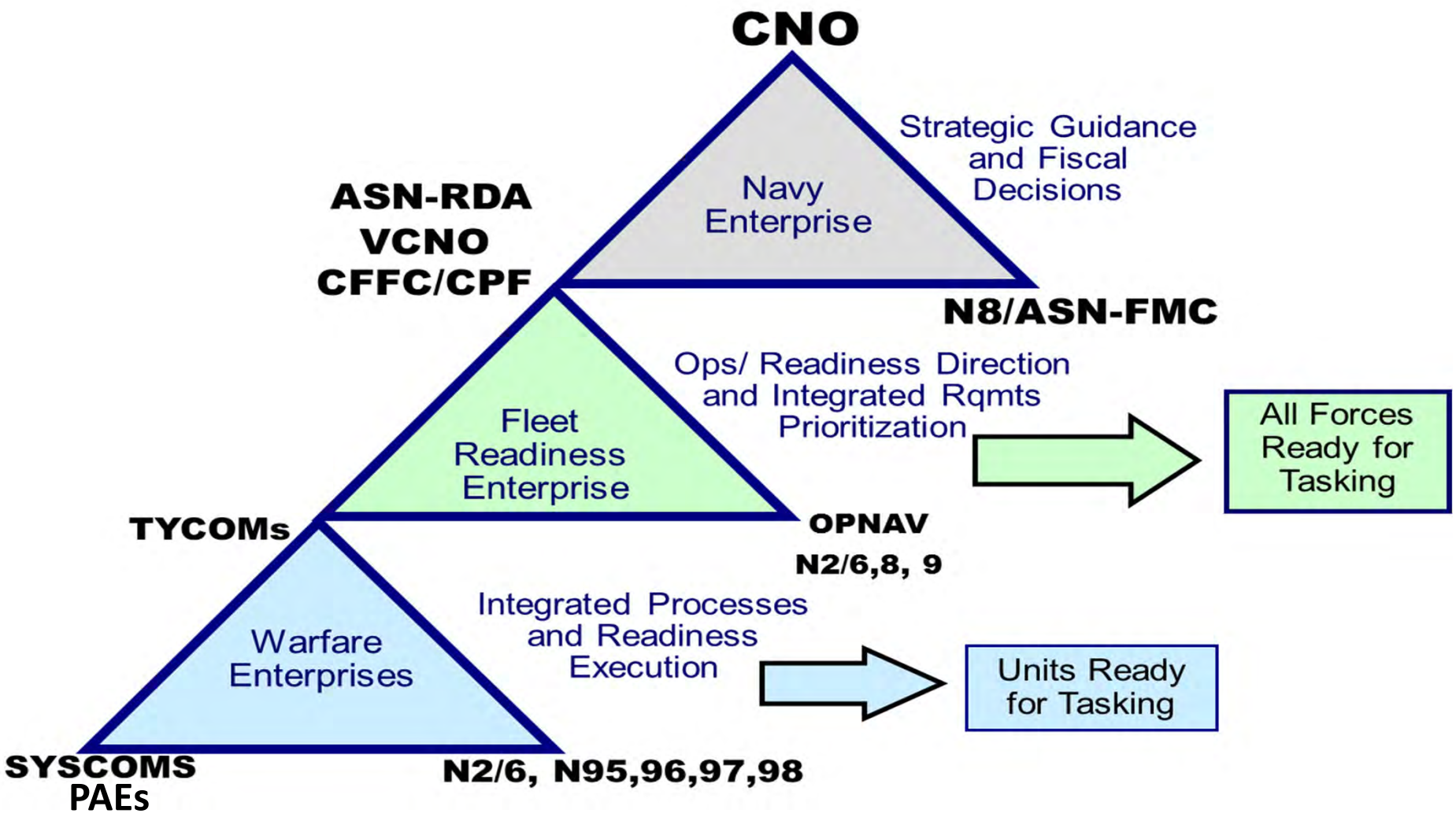
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- What is an "Enterprise"
- Key people
  - Engineering Duty Admirals

Enterprise Construct



Enterprise Construct; Scaled



Overview

- History of Goldwater-Nichols
- Major DoW/DoN components and reporting chains
  - Admin and Operational
- Deeper dive into DoN
  - SECNAV, CNO, ASN(RD&A), USFFC
- What is an “Enterprise”
- Key people
  - Engineering Duty Admirals

Your ED Flag Officers





Vice Admiral Okano
PMD, ASN(RD&A)



Vice Admiral Williams
PAE SSP





Rear Admiral Moton
Acting PAE Maritime



Rear Admiral Rothenhaus
Commander, NAVWAR
DPAE, Mission Systems



Rear Admiral Rucker
Director, Design & Construction
DRPM Subs/PAE Undersea

Your ED Flag Officers (cont.)



Rear Admiral Richman
SLCM-N



Rear Admiral Wolfson
Director, Fleet Maintenance,
US Atlantic Fleet



Rear Admiral Ettlich
Pacific Fleet N43



Rear Admiral Small
Acting COMNAVSEA



Rear Admiral) Lannamann
CNRMC



Rear Admiral Jett- Parmer
Acting – NAVSEA VCOM



Rear Admiral Metcalf
DPAE Maritime - Combatants

Summary

- What Act defines our current command structure?
- What are the major components of the Department of War?
- What are the major components of the Department of the Navy?

Summary

- What are the two separate Chains of Command?
- What is the difference between the Numbered and Type Commanders?
- Which SECNAV Principal Advisor is EDO community closely aligned to?
- Which CNO Principal Advisors are EDO community closely aligned to?

Summary

- What do each of these terms and acronyms stand for?
  - PAE
  - DRPM
  - OPNAV
  - Echelon

- What are key functions of Commander U. S. Fleet Forces Command?

Summary

- What are the three components of the Navy Enterprise Construct?